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POLITICS

'I am the Head of my Household, He is the Head of India's': How Narendra Modi Earned the Favour of the Indian Middle Class

Manoj Jangra — CRPF retiree and family business owner in South-West Delhi — explains, in his own words, why he supports Narendra Modi. A ground-level portrait of the political convictions and disappointments that built, and continue to sustain, the BJP's urban middle-class base.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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ABOUT

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Manoj Jangra, a small business owner in New Delhi's Dwarka, & a CRPF retiree tells us why he likes Modi, & you should too.

Hidden away in a basement in one of the many residential streets turned markets of South-West Delhi, is a photo framing shop run by a CRPF retiree & his homemaker-turned-craftswoman wife. They have three children & a nephew; Ms. Jangra's younger brother lives in the city with his wife & son, & quit his company job with terrible hours & terrible pay to work at the shop. It's a family business.

Paintings & bulk posters bought wholesale from Sadar Bazaar line the walls of the shop; Ram Vivah Pose A, Ram Vivah Pose B, Shiv Vivah (a rarity), Lakshmi Ganesh Sitting Pose ('Seated Gods are good luck'). Along with online orders of album posters & lyric art, the things that sell the most at their shop are Gods.

Mr. Jangra opened this shop back in 2014, after becoming disillusioned with the government institutions he was working for during the Lokpal Protests. If you ask him why he quit his job at the CRPF, he has a very clear answer. "Because of Kejriwal," he says.

"At the time there was Congress at the center, & the corruption was suffocating. There was no end to it. I wasn't even working for the government anymore, I was just working for individuals, all of them corrupt. Kejriwal used to speak so well. He fought the government fearlessly. He was so bold, he said he would pass the Lokpal bill, end the disparity. That these officers won't travel as VIPs anymore. They will be like us. I was very moved by his promises. I fell for them."

Today, thirteen years after the people of India took to the streets to fight Congress' rule of corruption, the Lokpal protests remain a testament to the power of public dissent. The roar of a nation, following the voice of a small, insignificant man. Arvind Kejriwal's words were powerful enough to move Manoj Jangra to reject a life of civil service, security, & a salary.

The Epic Photo Frames of today is a product of blood, sweat & tears, literally, as one finds out the hard way when one sets up a photo framing business from scratch. Mr. Jangra taught his wife & brother in law all they know today, but ten years ago, he had to teach himself.

Today though, Manoj Jangra has lost faith in Kejriwal. If you ask him why, he says it is because Kejriwal favors 'one side more than the other.' He thinks the AAP government appeases the poor, & neglects the middle class. He is too much on the side of the destitute, at the cost of those who aren't. Today, Epic Photo Frames is a well-respected & successful business, with regular patronage & a business network built upon trust & good practice, & Manoj Jangra is a well-respected man. He is everything that the Indian middle class strives to be; strong-willed, self-made, & opinionated. But the politician of his favor today is no longer the *Aam Aadmi*, but the *God*. The foremost frames upon entering his store are 2x3 sq. ft wall hangings of *Ram Lalla*, & the sticker on top of his storefront reads 'BJP ka Parivaar.'

Pros & Cons: 'Achchhaiyan Bhi Toh Ginwao.'

When business is slow & photoshop tutorials begin to bore him, Mr. Jangra likes to spend his time on politics. He is a frequent viewer of political commentary YouTubers like Mr. Munnabhai, The Jaipur Dialogues, Nitin Shukla, The Sham Sharma Show, & many more. Though he describes himself as strongly right-leaning, such YouTubers aren't all he is content to see. He is a curious man, a fastidious believer in critical thinking & finding things out for yourself. One of his favourite creators is a Pakistani YouTuber named Sohaib Chaudhry, who runs the channel Real Entertainment TV focusing on socio-economic & cultural exchange between India & Pakistan. He used to watch Dhruv Rathee, but doesn't anymore.

"Bobot hi negative way me lejata hai cheezon ko. Har cheez mei burai. Kabhi achhaia bhi toh ginwao." ("He is too negative about everything. Always recounting criticisms. One should take into account positives too.") Mr. Jangra does not believe it is reasonable to be so robustly critical of a government, regardless of elections, timing, & party promises. He is in fact afraid, that if the party currently in power should lose, whatever good is being done (little or not) will be lost. If you ask him to reiterate why he doesn't like Kejriwal's work in New Delhi, though, he recounts the things that dissatisfy him.

"Road dekho. Bahar bahar ke nahi, bahar bahar ke toh theek kara dete hai, kyunki whaan se toh ye netaon vagebra ki gaadiyan jayengi. Yahan jahan aam janta rehata hai, kitne kharaab kar rakhe hai. Meri scooty raise hi tooti this. Ab gareeb aadmi ko farak nahi padta, road kaisa ho. Toh ye kuchh nahi karte." ("Look at the roads. Not the main ones, of course, the main ones are all fixed up, that's where the ministers & the big men drive. But the ones here where ordinary men like me live, the roads are terrible. My scooty broke because of roads like these. But the poor don't care about roads. So they do nothing.")

On being asked to elaborate on what some examples of the purported good that the Central Government has done may be, though, his eyes light up. Contrary to what now under arrest Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal observed in his 2019 interview with Kunal Kamra, BJP supporters like Manoj Jangra do have an answer to the question (of just why it is that they like Mr. Narendra quite so much), & they have thought about it plenty.

What, Over the Past 10 Years, Should We be Grateful For?

"Ji pehli cheez toh hai security. Aaj se 10 saal pehle Dilli mei har jagah, buson mei, metro mei, sab jagah, announcement hote rehte the. 'Kisi anjaan vastu ko na chhuye isme bum ho sakta hai.' Aaj kal sunai deti hai kabin?" ("The first thing is security. 10 years ago you could hear announcements in Delhi, in the buses, metros, everywhere: 'Don't touch unidentified objects, they may contain bombs.' Do you hear them nowadays?")

Perhaps the answer to that question is no, we do not, because despite the familiar bomb warning: "any unattended or suspicious articles like briefcase, bag, toy, thermos or transistor, etc could be a bomb," being played on the Delhi Metro repeatedly, Mr. Jangra is confident that this is absolutely not the case.

Upon being asked whether he has attempted to verify this information or his hypothesis about them, Mr. Jangra is annoyed.

“*Isme check karne ka kya hai? Maine khud dekha hai apni aankhon se.*” (“*What is there to check? I’ve seen it with my own eyes.*”)

Confident observations like these are what form the basis of much of the politics of Mr. Jangra, as well as that of most ordinary Indians. This striking affinity for reason, logic, & critical thinking is characteristic of the Right Wing Indian - he does not believe in books, facts, or numbers. He believes only in what can be understood with logic. He believes only in his own observations, which he also believes he arrives at independently. After all, there is no evidence more damning than an eyewitness testimony.

In 2019, upon receiving complaints about the oversaturation of announcements on the Magenta Line, the DMRC announced that it would do away with 25 unessential announcements,^[1] & only 7 important ones would stay in place inside the trains. ‘Security’ announcements like bomb alerts are the first of these seven. But that is neither logic nor reason.

Speaking of reason, one might observe (as is highly encouraged) that a decrease in safety announcements is not necessarily or sufficiently implicative of an increase in *safety*. But one would be wrong. Upon asking Mr. Jangra why he thinks his observation implies or evidences his theory, he is again, annoyed. He does not like it when people refuse to use their own minds. He is not interested in proving to anyone what he thinks is obvious.

“*Mai khud soch nahi sakta kya?*” (“*Can’t I figure it out on my own?*”)

He can. And he is welcome to. Upon analysis of terrorism databases & reports^[2] by TVE it was found that there is indeed a correlation between terror attacks carried out before 2014 & after, just not the one Mr. Jangra suggests. On the contrary, the top five years in Indian history by number of terrorist incidents, are all from the Modi Regime. But then again, correlation is not causation. And what credibility does the Global Terrorist Database have, anyway, compared to an ex-CRPF officer (Retd. 2014) & a man with three generations’ worth of relatives all over India & the world?

When these statistics are quoted to him, he laughs in incredulity, finding them ridiculous.

“*You people will believe anything.*”

Another of the Modi government’s achievements that makes Mr. Jangra’s chest swell up with pride is the great strides India has made under its tenure in matters of military self-reliance.

“*Aaj se das saal pehle tak har cheez import hoti thi. Har bathiyaar. Koi bhi bathiyaar India mei nahi bante the. Aaj dekh lo. Haan jets vagehra toh import karne padte hi hai.*” (“*10 years ago everything used to be imported, every weapon. No weapon was made in India. Look at us now. Of course, we still have to import things like jets.*”)

This Hindustan Times article^[3] from 2012 illustrates just how abysmal India's position in global arms trade was before the Modi government came to power. Today, not only are our import rates lower, but our export rates are higher than ever. Much of this can be accredited to the strategic bans placed on imports of defense items over the last two years, which have now had four iterations. There has been an active push toward indigenisation, spearheaded by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, & it has not come without cost.

Domestic procurement alone in the military budget progressively increased from ₹51,000 crores in 2020 to nearly *twice* that at ₹1 Lakh crores in 2023^[4]. In contrast, the entire allocation for education in the same budget was ₹1.2 Lakh crores. This colossal jump in expenses is justified as being a temporary measure that will change India's military dependence & make room for self-reliance, but 12 years & 12 progressively increasing budgets later, we are *still* the world's largest importer of arms. We still don't feature in even the top 25 arms-exporting nations. India's import rates have gone down from 13% to 9.8%, a 3.2% decrease over 12 years, i.e. just 0.26% a year. The decrease of our reliance on Russia has been parallelly accompanied by an increase of that on the West. But one must not always be critical.

"Women's safety dekh lo. Buson mei aurton ke liye free ticketein. Transport. Bijli paani ki suvidhaayein. Bobot kuch badla hai. Bobot kuch behtar hua hai. Jab mai Dilli aaya tha toh hamara sir ke upar bulb tak nahi hota tha. Ham andhere mei rehte the." ("Look at women's safety. There's free tickets for women in city buses. Transport, water & electricity facilities. Much has changed. Much has improved. When I came to Delhi we didn't even have a lightbulb above our heads. We used to live in the darkness.")

Notably, free tickets for women in buses, free water & electricity for residential consumption, & last mile connectivity are all initiatives of the Aam Aadmi Party-run Delhi government, that have been taken, incidentally, also in the last 10 years.

When reminded that transport, electricity, & water are jurisdictions of the state government, Mr. Jangra clarifies that he is speaking of improvements made to the nation at large. All of which, at the end of the day, are being made at the helm of the leader of the country: the Prime Minister.

"Ab dekho, apna ghar mai chalata hun. Mere ghar mei kuch bhi achha hoga, meri beti tournament jeetegi ya mera beta afsar banega, toh ye meri bhi achievement hogi. Desh Pradhman mantri chalata hai." ("Look, I run my house. An achievement in my house - say, my daughter wins a tournament or my son becomes an officer - is my achievement too. The Prime Minister runs the country.")

Moving on from the impasse, Mr. Jangra began to conclude his argument. But a push for military self-reliance, a questionable idea of security, & the PMUY (Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana) scheme are far from the only ones on the long list of initiatives taken by the BJP-led Central government over the past ten years that the average middle-class man rooting for Narendra Modi can recount.

They must be.

When asked to go on listing examples, Mr. Jangra promises to think & find more when he has the time. He hadn't prepared for a presentation, after all.

In the conversation that follows, the mood is nudged away from the intense & political to lighthearted small talk & chit chat. Now that the procedural part of the interview is over, our correspondent offers commentary of their own on all that's changed for the better in the Modi regime. A UPI payment card on the table can be seen standing out on the table, bright with colors of the Indian flag; *Bharat Interface for Money*.

Interestingly, India's one-of-a-kind UPI system is not a matter of pride to Mr. Jangra. He hardly even believes that Western nations & china did not invent the technology first.

"Haan par America ke paas toh aur pehle se tha," ("But America had the tech even earlier.") he says, unsure, before our correspondent explains that he is confusing e-commerce technology with UPI, a payments interface developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). He laughs, embarrassed, explaining that he is not very well-versed in these things. He doesn't even have Paytm on his phone & prefers to use cash; the QR codes in his shop are a necessity of the trade. But he accepts our correspondent's praise for the technology with an open mind nevertheless.

"I personally depend quite a bit on UPI. A lot of people I know do. It is absurdly convenient," she starts. "It is strange to think that for all matters that India is supposed to be behind so called 'developed nations,' a man who has lived here & is used to Paytm, Gpay, & the likes being the norm, will feel nothing but downgraded to move to say, a country like the US, that hasn't yet figured out anything even close. As a matter of fact, there are talks of international collaboration in progress right now, including with the US itself. UPI is a resource that India has built upon, that proves that time & money spent on infrastructural development still count for leverage in current world politics. New-age banking systems like the IMPS & UPI are what India has to export."

She does not mention that the NPCI itself was established back in 2008, & its ownership has since been shared between several promoter banks, mostly private ones, & that Narendra Modi neither funded, initiated, nor endorsed the efforts behind making UPI a success, as he did later on & with RuPay.^[5]

Mr. Jangra smiles at the monologue, happy to see that his encouragement to look at the bright side stuck. "Fir log kehte hai vikaas nahi hota." ("And then people say there isn't development.")

'Achhaiyan Bhi Toh Ginwao' is a new irregular TVE Ground Report series started in response to your feedback. In an attempt to meet the audience halfway with their reluctance to engage with media that is 'overly' critical of the powers that be, Achaiyan Bhi Toh Ginwao will attempt to, wherever possible, take a glass half full approach with reporting, but what it will also do & perhpas more importantly so, is dissect this desire for positive reportage itself.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



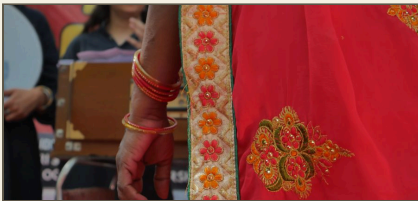
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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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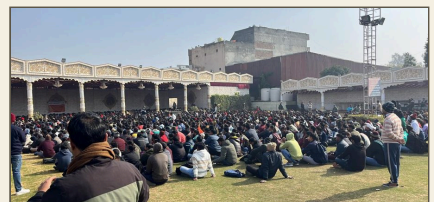
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[3] Hindustan Times article

[4] twicethat at ₹1 Lakh crores in 2023

[5] RuPay.